

Algorithms, AI & Data Science II

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Notes:

- **L06: Satisfiability in Propositional Logic** 19.05.2025
- **Educational objective:** We define the satisfiability problem in propositional logic and consider the DPLL algorithm. We introduce logical inference and show how we can use rules of inference to infer logical conclusions.
 - Satisfiability in Propositional Logic
 - Logical Inference and Rules of Inference
 - Forward Reasoning
- **Handout version:** 2025/05/19 10:01:33

Motivation

- ▶ we introduced **propositional logic**, a context-free formal language that can be used to **represent knowledge**
- ▶ propositional logic consists of **logically connected propositions**, e.g.

$$X_0 \wedge X_1 \implies X_2$$

- ▶ introducing Boolean algebra, we took an **algebraic perspective on formal logics**

open questions

- ▶ how can we use propositional logic to **automatically reason** about the world?
- ▶ how can we check whether a **formula can possibly evaluate to true** (for any variable assignment)?

X_0	X_1	$X_0 \implies X_1$	$X_0 \wedge \neg X_1$
False	False	True	False
False	True	True	False
True	False	False	True
True	True	True	False

Notes:

Satisfiability problem

- ▶ for propositional formula F with n variables X_i we call $\mathcal{A} : (X_0, \dots, X_n) \rightarrow \{True, False\}^n$ **assignment**
- ▶ $\mathcal{A}(F)$ denotes truth value of F for assignment $\mathcal{A}$
- ▶ we say that **assignment $\mathcal{A}$ satisfies F** iff $\mathcal{A}(F) = True$ (we write $\mathcal{A} \models F$ and call $\mathcal{A}$ “model” for F)

satisfiability for propositional logic

Propositional formula F is **satisfiable** iff there is an assignment $\mathcal{A}$ with $\mathcal{A} \models F$. Otherwise we say that F is **unsatisfiable**.

- ▶ how can we solve **word decision problem** for language $L = \{F \mid F \text{ is satisfiable formula in propositional logic}\}$
- ▶ we can use **truth table enumeration algorithm**, i.e. for propositional logic satisfiability is **decidable**

example 1

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_2)$$

For $\mathcal{A}(X_0, X_1, X_2) = (False, True, False)$ we have $\mathcal{A}(F) = True$

$\mathcal{A} \models F$ and thus F is **satisfiable**

example 2

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_1)$$

$\mathcal{A}(F) = False$ for **any assignment $\mathcal{A}$** and thus F is **not satisfiable**

Notes:

Cook-Levin theorem

- ▶ for formula with n variables, **truth table has 2^n rows**, i.e. time complexity is in $2^{O(n)}$
- ▶ can we find a **faster (polynomial-time) algorithm**?

Cook-Levin theorem

Satisfiability problem in propositional logic is NP-complete, i.e. there is no known polynomial-time algorithm that can decide whether a given formula is satisfiable or not.

- ▶ central result in computer science because **many problems can be reduced to satisfiability**
- ▶ reducing a problem A to (Boolean) satisfiability implies that **satisfiability** is at least as difficult as A
- ▶ any polynomial-time algorithm for satisfiability would imply that we can also solve A in polynomial time



Stephen Arthur Cook, born 1939

image credit: Wikimedia Commons, Jiří Janíček, CC-BY-SA

Notes:

SAT-solvers and backtracking

- ▶ consider satisfiability problem for propositional formula F in **conjunctive normal form**
- ▶ confirming that F is unsatisfiable may require exponential time but clever **search algorithms** can **find satisfying assignment** (iff F is satisfiable)
- ▶ we can use trial-and-error based **backtracking algorithm** to find $\mathcal{A}$ with $\mathcal{A} \models F$
 - ▶ select variable and **assign truth value**
 - ▶ use **annulment and identity law** to simplify formula
 - ▶ return **satisfiable if simplified formula is empty**
 - ▶ abandon assignment (“backtrack”) if simplified formula contains empty clause (i.e. is unsatisfiable)
- ▶ SAT-solvers are important basis for **automated theorem proving and logical inference**

backtracking algorithm

1. **choose variable** X_i and set $X_i = \text{True}$ or $X_i = \text{False}$
2. **simplify F** by
 - (i) removing clauses where literal evaluates to *True*
 - (ii) removing literals that evaluate to *False* from remaining clauses
3. if **simplified formula is empty** then F is satisfiable, i.e. return True
4. if **simplified formula contains empty clause**, assign complementary value to X_i and repeat (or return False if we have tried all assignments)

example 1

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_2)$$

setting $X_0 = \text{True}$ **we can simplify** to

$$F = \cancel{(X_0 \vee X_1)} \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge \cancel{(\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1)} \wedge \cancel{(\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1)} \wedge \cancel{(X_0 \vee \bar{X}_2)}$$

Notes:

Group exercise 06-01

1/2

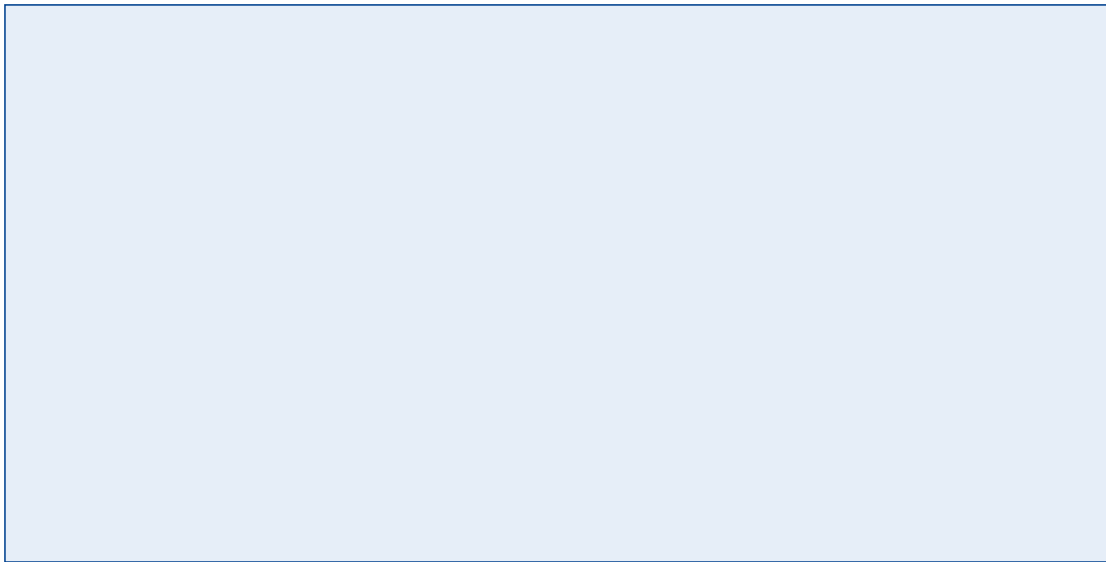
Apply backtracking to check the satisfiability of the following formula

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_2)$$

Notes:

Group exercise 06-01

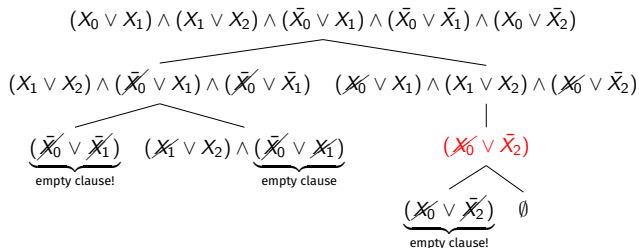
2/2



Notes:

Improving naive backtracking

- ▶ execution of backtracking algorithm defines a **search tree**
- ▶ cancel search along branch if **partial solution** cannot yield desired result
- ▶ naive backtracking is an **uninformed search strategy** that randomly assigns variables in each step
- ▶ idea: improve performance by using **smarter search strategy** that considers properties of propositional logic?
- ▶ is it reasonable to set $X_2 = \text{True}$ if formula contains **unit clause** $\bar{X}_2$?



formula is satisfiable for assignment
 $\mathcal{A} = (X_0, X_1, X_2) = (\text{False}, \text{True}, \text{False})$

Notes:

DPLL algorithm

- ▶ consider formula F in CNF as a **set of clauses** $\{c_1, \dots, c_k\}$
- ▶ **Davis-Putnam-Logemann-Loveland (DPLL) algorithm** improves basic backtracking with **two additional rules that speed up search**

→ M Davis, H Putnam, 1960

→ M Davis, G Logemann, D Loveland, 1961

DPLL search rules

1. **unit propagation:** if clause has single variable X_i (i.e. it is “unit clause”) assign value to X_i such that clause evaluates to true, remove unit clause, and remove X_i from clauses where it appears as complement
2. **pure variable elimination:** if variable X_i has the same polarity in all clauses where it appears (i.e. it is “pure”), assign value to X_i such that those clauses evaluate to *True* and remove those clauses

DPLL algorithm

```
procedure DPLL( $F$ )
  while there is unit clause  $\{X_i\}$  in  $F$  do
     $F \leftarrow \text{unit-propagate}(X_i, F)$ 
  end while
  while there is pure variable  $\{X_i\}$  in  $F$  do
     $F \leftarrow \text{pure-variable-assign}(X_i, F)$ 
  end while
  if  $F$  is empty then
    return True
  end if
  if  $F$  contains empty clause then
    return False
  end if
   $X_i \leftarrow \text{choose-variable}(F)$ 
  return  $\text{DPLL}(F \wedge \{X_i\}) \vee \text{DPLL}(F \wedge \{\bar{X}_i\})$ 
end procedure
```

Notes:

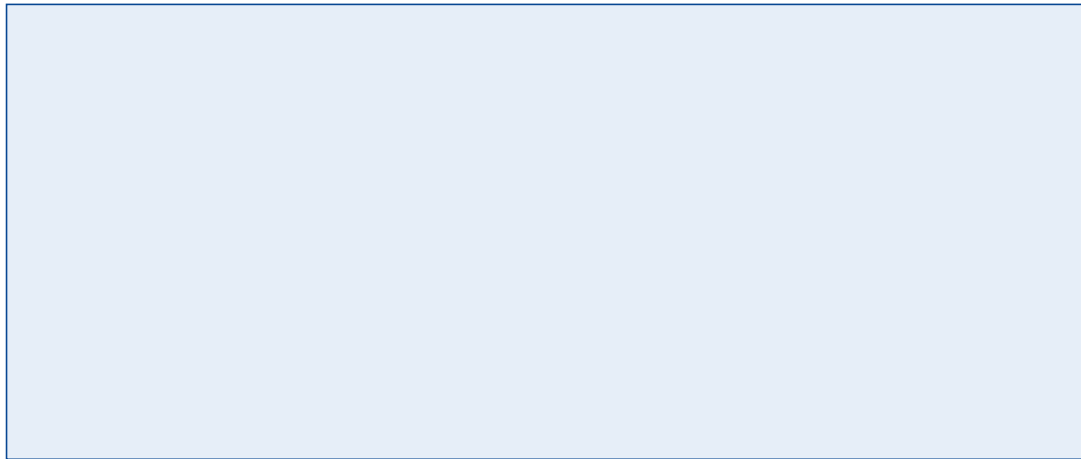
1. We use unit propagation because if a variable appears in a unit clause, the formula can only be satisfied with the assignment of a corresponding truth value
2. We use pure variable elimination because by setting the variable to a truth value that makes all clauses true in which it appears, those clauses do not impose constraints for the choice of other variables in the search tree, i.e. we can always satisfy all of those clauses just by setting the single pure variable accordingly. In other words, setting the pure variable to the complementary value can only make the search for a satisfying assignment harder (as we impose additional constraints for the other variables).

Group exercise 06-02

1/2

- Use the DPLL algorithm to **find a satisfying assignment** for the following propositional formula F in CNF.

$$(X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge \bar{X}_1 \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_2)$$



Notes:

Group exercise 06-02

2/2

- Use the DPLL algorithm to show that the following propositional formula F is **unsatisfiable**.

$$(X_1 \vee X_0) \wedge (X_0 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_2 \vee X_0) \wedge (\bar{X}_2 \vee \bar{X}_0) \wedge (X_2 \vee \bar{X}_0)$$

Notes:

Practice Session

- ▶ we implement the **DPLL algorithm** to check propositional satisfiability in python
- ▶ we use our implementation to check the satisfiability of propositional formulas.

05-01 Logical Inference

May 3, 2023
Ingo Scholtes

```
1 import pandas as pd
2 import itertools

3
4 def implies(x, y):
5     return not(x) or y
6
7 def biconditional(x, y):
8     return x == y
9
10
11 def check_implication(knowledge, query, variables):
12     # generate truth table
13     tt = []
14     for assignment in itertools.product([False, True], repeat=len(variables)):
15         row = [x for x in assignment]
16         row.append(knowledge(*assignment))
17         row.append(query(*assignment))
18         row.append(implies(knowledge(*assignment), query(*assignment)))
19         tt.append(row)
20     labels = variables
21     labels.append('kb')
22     labels.append('query')
23     labels.append('implication')
24     tt = pd.DataFrame(tt, columns=labels)
25     print(tt)
26
27     # check whether the implication holds
28     return tt['implication'].all()
29
30
31 check_implication(knowledge = lambda x0, x1: implies(x0, x1) and x0,
32                  query = lambda x0, x1: x1,
33                  variables=['x0', 'x1'])
```

practice session

see notebooks 06-01 in gitlab repository at

→ https://gitlab.informatik.uni-wuerzburg.de/ml4nets_notebooks/2025_sose_akids2

Notes:

In summary ...

- ▶ we explored the **satisfiability problem** in propositional logic
- ▶ propositional satisfiability is a **decidable but NP-complete problem**
- ▶ we considered backtracking, a naive uninformed search algorithm that can be used as a basis for **SAT-solvers**
- ▶ we considered the **backtracking-based DPLL algorithm** that uses unit-propagation and pure-variable elimination to speed up search
- ▶ SAT-solvers are important foundation for **logical inference**



DALL-E image generated for prompt “an image that represents the relation between formal logics and symbolic artificial intelligence”

[image credit: www.bing.com](https://www.bing.com)

Notes:

Self-study questions

1. Use truth table enumeration to determine the satisfiability of the following formula:

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_2)$$

2. Use the DPLL algorithm to show that the following formula is not satisfiable:

$$F = (X_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (X_1 \vee X_2) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee X_1) \wedge (\bar{X}_0 \vee \bar{X}_1) \wedge (X_0 \vee \bar{X}_1)$$

3. Explain why empty clauses in the DPLL algorithm indicates that F is not satisfiable.
4. Explain why an empty formula in the DPLL algorithm indicates that F is satisfiable.
5. Give an example for an unsatisfiable formula without pure variables or unit clauses.
6. Explain the reasoning behind the unit propagation and the pure variable elimination rules in the DPLL algorithm.
7. Try to construct an example for a propositional formula in which the unit propagation and pure variable elimination rules in DPLL can not be applied a single time.
8. Investigate algorithms to solve the so-called 2-satisfiability problem (2-SAT) for propositional formulas in CNF with exactly two propositional variables. How does the complexity of this problem differ from the general satisfiability problem in propositional logic?

Notes:

References

reading list

- ▶ M Davis and H Putnam: **A Computing Procedure for Quantification Theory**. Journal of the ACM. 7 (3), 1960
- ▶ M Davis, G Logemann, D Loveland: **A Machine Program for Theorem Proving**, Communications of the ACM. 5 (7), 1961
- ▶ B Nebel: **Logics for Knowledge Representation**, Int. Encyc. Social and Behavioral Sciences, 2001
- ▶ S Hedman: **A First Course in Logic**, Oxford Texts in Logic, 2004
- ▶ U Schöning: **Logik für Informatiker**, Spektrum Akad. Verlag, 2005
- ▶ DE Knuth: **The Art of Computer Programming 4A: Combinatorial Algorithms**, chapter 7
- ▶ S Russel and P Norvig: **Artificial Intelligence: A modern Approach**, 2022, chapter 7

acknowledgments

examples partly based on the following books and lectures:

- ▶ V Goranko: **First-Order Logic: Satisfiability, validity, logical consequence**, DTU, 2010
- ▶ C Meinel, M Mundhenk: **Mathematische Grundlagen der Informatik**, Springer, 2014
- ▶ S Russel and P Norvig: **Artificial Intelligence: A modern Approach**, 2022 → section 7.5

A Computing Procedure for Quantification Theory*

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The hope that mathematical methods employed in the investigation of formal logic would lead to purely computational methods for obtaining mathematical theorems goes back to Leibniz and has been revived by Peano around the turn of the century and by Hilbert's school in the 1920's. Hilbert, noting that all of classical mathematics could be formalized within quantification theory, declared that the problem of finding an algorithm for determining whether or not a given formula of quantification theory is valid was the central problem of mathematical logic. And indeed, at one time it seemed as if investigations of this "decision" problem were on the verge of success. However, it was shown by Church and by Turing that such an algorithm can not exist. This result led to considerable pessimism regarding the possibility of using modern digital computers in deciding significant mathematical questions. However, recently there has been a revival of interest in the whole question. Specifically, it has been realized that while no decision procedure exists for quantification theory there are many proof procedures available—that is, uniform procedures which will ultimately locate a proof for any formula of quantification theory which is valid but which will usually involve seeking "forever" in the case of a formula which is not valid—and that some of these proof procedures could well turn out to be feasible for use with modern computing machinery.

Hao Wang [9] and P. C. Gilmore [3] have each produced working programs which employ proof procedures in quantification theory. Gilmore's program employs a form of a basic theorem of mathematical logic due to Herbrand, and Wang's makes use of a formulation of quantification theory related to those studied by Gentzen. However, both programs encounter decisive difficulties with any but the simplest formulas of quantification theory, in connection with methods of doing propositional calculus. Wang's program, because of its use of Gentzen-like methods, involves exponentiation on the total number of truth-functional connectives, whereas Gilmore's program, using normal forms, involves exponentiation on the number of clauses present. Both methods are superior in many cases to truth table methods which involve exponentiation on the

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